WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SWITZERLAND

Europe

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Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Zurich	Largest economy and financial centre, home to the SIX Swiss Exchange, global banks, insurers and technology companies; cantonal tax was cut in 2026	Finance, insurance, technology, AI, professional services
Basel	Global life-sciences hub and base of major pharmaceutical and chemicals groups, on the borders with France and Germany	Pharmaceuticals, biotech, chemicals, logistics
Geneva and the Lake Geneva region (Lausanne)	International city hosting UN agencies and NGOs, commodity traders and private banks, with EPFL in Lausanne as a technology and research anchor	Commodity trading, private banking, international organisations, life sciences, technology
Lucerne and Zug (central Switzerland)	Lowest-tax cantons, with maximum effective corporate tax rates of 11.66% in Lucerne and 11.71% in Zug in 2026	Holding and headquarters companies, trading, blockchain and fintech
Bern	Federal capital and seat of the Federal Council, the Swiss National Bank and federal administration	Public sector, medtech, precision engineering
Ticino	Italian-speaking canton linked to Milan through the Gotthard rail corridor	Fashion and logistics, private banking, life sciences

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Switzerland Global Enterprise, the national promotion agency, works with cantonal economic development agencies, which handle sites, permits and incentives directly with investors
- Competitive cantonal taxation: maximum effective corporate tax rates range from about 11.7% in Lucerne and Zug to around 20% in Zurich and Bern, with patent boxes available; the OECD 15% minimum tax applies to large multinational groups
- No general foreign-investment screening regime for most sectors, with sector-specific rules in areas such as banking, real estate and broadcasting; investors should check the status of proposed screening legislation
- A freely convertible Swiss franc and no capital controls, with free repatriation of profits and capital
- Swiss Exchange (SIX) listings and access to one of the world's deepest pools of private and institutional capital
- Access to EU markets under the bilateral agreements, and to over 30 free trade partners through EFTA and Swiss agreements, including the EFTA–India agreement

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Switzerland offers investors political stability, a strong currency, low taxes and world-class research and financial infrastructure. Growth has surprised on the upside in 2026: in September the State Secretariat for Economic Affairs (SECO) raised its 2026 GDP forecast to 1.7% from 0.9%, with 1.6% expected in 2027, and unemployment forecast at 3.1%. Inflation remains among the lowest in Europe at 1.5% in October 2026, and the Swiss National Bank held its policy rate at 0% in September. The stock of foreign direct investment in Switzerland was CHF 926 billion at the end of 2024. Eight cantons cut their corporate tax rates in 2026, and in June 2026 voters rejected an initiative to cap the population at 10 million, preserving the current immigration and labour-market framework.

Switzerland's main structural challenge is securing its trading relationships with its two largest partners, the EU and the United States. The EU treaty package, signed in Brussels on 2 March 2026, updates access to the single market and adds new agreements on health, food safety and electricity; parliament is still debating it, and one or more referendums are expected in 2027 or 2028. With the United States, a November 2025 framework cut tariffs on Swiss goods from 39% to 15%; after the US Supreme Court's February 2026 ruling on emergency tariffs, a 10% general duty and up to 15% on pharmaceuticals applied, and talks on a binding agreement continue. Switzerland's resilience is considerable: federal finances recorded a CHF 0.3 billion surplus in 2025 under the debt brake, the franc is a global safe haven, and diversified FTAs open alternative markets.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US tariffs and trade-deal uncertainty	US duties on Swiss goods have changed several times since August 2025, and a binding US–Swiss agreement has not yet been concluded	Monitor SECO updates, use EFTA FTAs to diversify markets, and consider US production where tariffs are material
EU treaty package ratification	The package is still in parliament and must pass one or more referendums, expected in 2027 or 2028	Existing bilateral agreements continue in force; plan EU market access on current rules and track the vote
Strong franc and high costs	The franc's safe-haven status and high wages raise costs for exporters and new operations	Focus on high-value activities, use the SNB's stated readiness to act in currency markets, and hedge currency exposure
Banking capital reform	Parliament is debating higher capital requirements for UBS, potentially up to $20 billion; a final decision is unlikely before 2027	Swiss banking remains well regulated; financial-sector investors should follow the legislation closely
Minimum tax and cantonal tax differences	The OECD 15% minimum tax applies to large groups, and rates vary widely between cantons	Take specialist advice and compare cantonal offers, including patent boxes and R&D deductions
Federal budget pressures	Structural deficits of CHF 2 to 4 billion are projected for 2027–29, prompting a savings programme	The debt brake keeps finances sound; watch for changes to subsidies and indirect taxes
Skilled labour and permits	Demand for skilled workers is high, and non-EU staff are subject to quotas	EU/EFTA nationals benefit from free movement; plan non-EU hiring early with cantonal authorities

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Switzerland is one of the world's most stable and creditworthy investment destinations, with low public debt, a federal surplus in 2025, inflation of 1.5% and a direct democracy that gives policy a high degree of predictability. The main issues for investors are external: US trade policy, where Switzerland has a non-binding framework deal and talks continue on a binding agreement, and the EU treaty package, which still faces parliamentary approval and referendums. Investors should also note that Switzerland generally applies EU sanctions against Russia, and that the OECD minimum tax affects large groups. Switzerland is a FATF member and is not on the FATF list of jurisdictions under increased monitoring. These factors are manageable with good advice, and the franc, deep capital markets and strong institutions give investors exceptional resilience.

MARKET ACCESS

Switzerland is not a member of the EU or the EEA, but a network of bilateral agreements gives Swiss-based companies wide access to the EU single market, which remains its main trading partner; the EU treaty package signed in March 2026 is designed to update and secure that access. As a member of EFTA and the WTO, Switzerland has a large network of free trade agreements, including the EFTA–India Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement, and an EFTA–Mercosur agreement awaits parliamentary approval. The United States is a key market, especially for pharmaceuticals, and Swiss companies have pledged $200 billion of US investment by the end of 2028 under the November 2025 framework. Switzerland is also a member of the Schengen area, and the Gotthard and Lötschberg rail tunnels connect northern and southern Europe.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Federal Council (President and Economy Minister Guy Parmelin in 2026)	Seven-member collegial government that sets policy and leads trade negotiations with the EU and the United States	Primary reference point for national economic and trade policy
Switzerland Global Enterprise and cantonal economic development agencies	National promotion agency working with cantonal agencies that negotiate sites, permits and tax arrangements	First point of contact for market entry and location comparisons
Swiss National Bank (SNB)	Independent central bank; policy rate 0% since 2025 and willing to act in foreign-exchange markets as necessary	Relevant for currency, rates and financial-stability matters
Federal Department of Finance (Karin Keller-Sutter)	Leads federal budget, tax policy, the debt brake and banking legislation, including the UBS capital reform	Key counterpart on tax and financial-sector policy
State Secretariat for Economic Affairs (SECO)	Leads trade policy, economic forecasting and the US tariff negotiations	Key source on trade agreements and tariff changes
FINMA	Independent financial-market supervisor for banks, insurers and asset managers	Licensing and supervision for financial-services investors
SIX Swiss Exchange	Main Swiss stock exchange and financial-market infrastructure operator	Listings, capital raising and fintech partnerships

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

Economiesuisse, the main federation of Swiss business, and sector bodies such as scienceindustries for chemicals and pharmaceuticals and Swiss Medtech are influential voices in policy debates on trade and tax. Bilateral chambers including the Swiss-American Chamber of Commerce, the British-Swiss Chamber of Commerce and the Swiss Chambers of Commerce network provide introductions and market intelligence. Cantonal economic development agencies, regional promotion bodies such as Greater Zurich Area and Greater Geneva Bern area, and Switzerland Global Enterprise organise investor programmes. Universities such as ETH Zurich and EPFL, and Innosuisse, the innovation agency, are important partners for research collaboration.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Switzerland suits investors seeking a stable, low-tax base for high-value activity: regional headquarters and holding companies in Zug, Lucerne and Zurich; life-sciences, medtech and chemical companies in Basel and the Lake Geneva region; financial-services, wealth-management, fintech and commodity-trading firms in Zurich and Geneva; and research-intensive technology and AI companies working with ETH Zurich and EPFL. Exporters to the United States and the EU should plan for evolving trade arrangements on both fronts.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Compare cantons with Switzerland Global Enterprise
Use the national agency to shortlist cantons, then negotiate sites, permits and tax arrangements with cantonal development agencies.

STEP 2: Take tax advice on cantonal rates and the minimum tax
Model effective rates, patent boxes and R&D deductions alongside the OECD 15% minimum tax for large groups.

STEP 3: Assess EU and US market access
Map exposure to US tariffs and to the EU treaty package, and plan supply chains on current rules while tracking negotiations and votes.

STEP 4: Plan staffing and permits early
Use EU/EFTA free movement where possible and apply early for non-EU work permits under cantonal quotas.

STEP 5: Connect with research and business networks
Build links with ETH Zurich, EPFL and Innosuisse, and with economiesuisse and bilateral chambers, for partnerships and policy insight.